

Session 22: Ancient Cosmology in Psalm 36

Key Takeaways

- Psalm 36 displays the same ancient cosmology we've been looking at in Genesis 1—the heavens above, the deep below, and the dry land in between.
- In the psalm, the dry land can be used as an image for the space of the wicked even though, as the psalm says, God's love and justice extend from the heavens all the way to the deep. The psalm exposes this tension between two realities.

Psalm 36: Another Example of Ancient Cosmology

Psalm 36 ESV

¹ Transgression speaks to the wicked
deep in his heart;
there is no fear of God
before his eyes.

² For he flatters himself in his own eyes
that his iniquity cannot be found out and hated.

³ The words of his mouth are trouble and deceit;
he has ceased to act wisely and do good.

⁴ He plots trouble while on his bed;
he sets himself in a way that is not good;
he does not reject evil.

⁵ Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens,
your faithfulness to the clouds.

⁶ Your righteousness is like the mountains of God;
your judgments are like the great deep;
man and beast you save, O LORD.

⁷ How precious is your steadfast love, O God!
The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.

⁸ They feast on the abundance of your house,
and you give them drink from the river of your delights.

⁹ For with you is the fountain of life;
in your light do we see light.

¹⁰ Oh, continue your steadfast love to those who know you,
and your righteousness to the upright of heart!

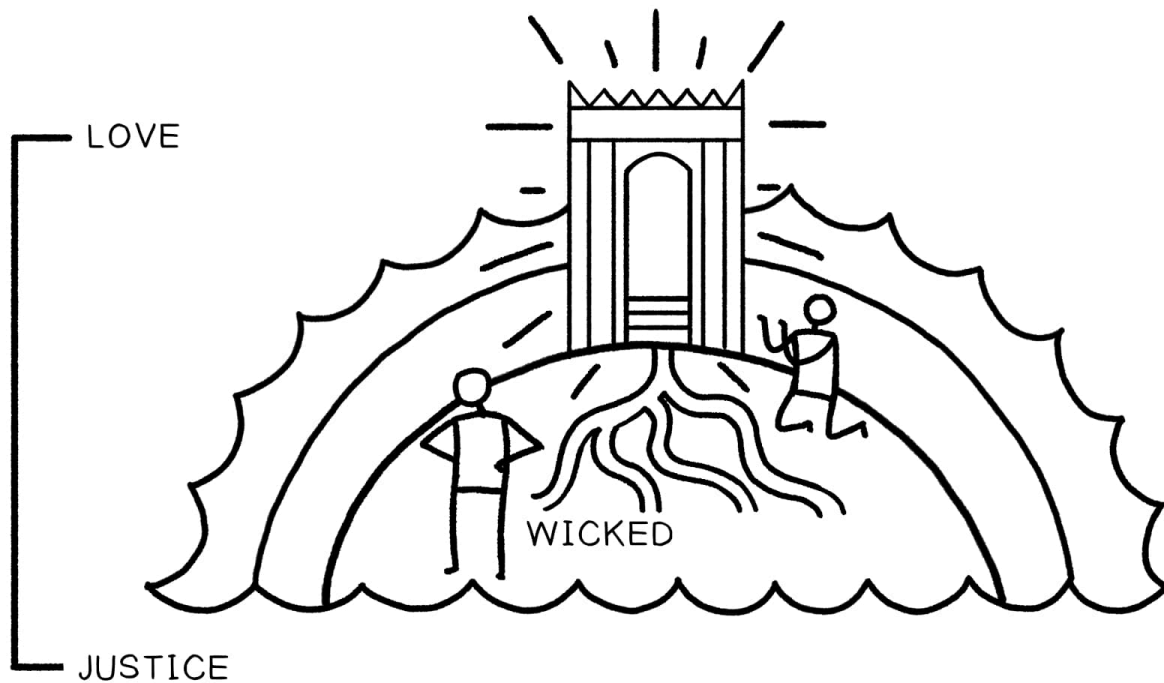
¹¹ Let not the foot of arrogance come upon me,

nor the hand of the wicked drive me away.

¹² There the evildoers lie fallen;
they are thrust down, unable to rise.

Reflection on Psalm 36

What do you notice about ancient cosmology and the shape of the cosmos in Psalm 36?



The Land of the Wicked. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Reflection Question

What's something that stands out to you from Psalm 36 that relates to this ancient cosmology we've been discussing? The elements of the biblical cosmos (the dry land, the heavens, the deep) correspond to different characteristics. What do they symbolize?